Blue in cultures and traditions

Blue is a colour that people for a long time had nothing to make from, and yet today it is given in surveys as the favourite. Every culture reads it in its own way. Sky, protection, **sadness** and divinity. None of these meanings excludes the others. Let us look at a few places and read them well.

This chapter therefore shows two levels. First, how blue is read in different cultures, and then how traditional systems look at it, using it as an image.

Blue in different cultures

Ancient Egypt

Egyptian blue is considered the first artificial pigment. The oldest evidence dates from around 3250 BC. It was made by heating quartz sand, a copper compound, lime and an alkali (natural soda or ash) to roughly 800 to 1000 °C.

The Egyptians linked blue with sky and water. The pigment was used on paintings, statues and small objects. After antiquity the method of production was lost for a long time and modern chemistry reconstructed it only later. A curiosity. Egyptian blue glows in infrared light, and thanks to that its traces can be found even on objects that look uncoloured.

Blue was not a gift of nature, but an invention.

Greece and Turkey

The blue glass amulet nazar (in Turkish *nazar boncuğu*, in Greek *mati*, “eye”) is meant to protect against an **envious** gaze, the so-called evil eye. You find it on houses, in cars and on jewellery.

Belief in the evil eye is very old and widespread around the Mediterranean and the Middle East. The amulet looks back and is meant to turn aside a bad glance. According to folk belief the evil eye is more often ascribed to people with light eyes, who are rarer in these countries.

Blue here means neither **sadness** nor coldness, but protection. The same colour can be a shield, not just a mood colour.

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India

In Hinduism Krishna and Rama, incarnations of the god Vishnu, are often depicted with blue or dark blue skin. Water and the ocean are linked with Vishnu; Shiva too is sometimes depicted in a bluish shade.

It is an iconographic tradition and there is more than one interpretation. Most often blue is read as infinity, sky and ocean. Something that has no boundary and cannot be grasped.

Blue here has no connection with sadness. It means **depth** and the infinite, that is something greater than us.

Japan

In Japan blue is the colour of indigo (in Japanese *ai*), that is the deep, dark blue of fabrics and craft. It is connected with traditional techniques such as *shibori* or *kasuri*.

In the Edo period (1603 to 1868) common people were forbidden to wear silk. Cotton spread and indigo was one of the few dyes with which it could be coloured well. A frugal garment thus became a beautiful, respected tradition.

A restriction can give birth to beauty. A colour that came from necessity became a symbol of simplicity and craft.

Blue in traditional systems

Every tradition looks at blue a little differently, but all take it seriously. It is an old symbolic language and an inspiration, not a healing guide.

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Traditional Chinese medicine

In the Chinese tradition there are five elements. Wood, fire, earth, metal and water. With blue it is more complicated than with other colours. The old Chinese word qing (青) denotes blue and green together and in the list of the five elements belongs to wood. Water in the tradition is linked with black or dark blue, with winter, cold, the salty taste, the kidneys and bladder and the emotion of **fear**. Wisdom and the ability to flow are also grouped with it.

Water is in the Chinese tradition the element of **depth**, **calm** and rest. It is under the surface and waits. When there is enough of it, we are calm, patient and have a reserve. When there is little, the tradition describes exhaustion and **anxiety**. When there is too much, it tends to be a cold closing-off and **fear**.

How it relates to the colour blue. Dark blue is in the tradition the colour of water, that is of **depth**, rest and reserves. Water feeds wood, which is why dark blue is complemented by green. A lighter blue is then read rather as sky and **lightness**.

What you can take from it. Ask yourself whether you have enough water in your life, that is rest and reserves. If not, sleep, warmth, slow eating and **quiet** help. When there is too much water and you are rather withdrawn and fearful, movement, warmth (fire) and small steps outward help.

If I asked you now

"Do you have enough rest in your life?"

Why water, and why is it blue in one place and black in another?

In the basic colour map of the five elements black belongs to water. In some contemporary readings a deep blue to blue-black appears next to it, which is why you find two seemingly different tables. When you read "kidneys" in this teaching, imagine the broader traditional circle of water, the storing of strength and the vital essence jing. It is not a reserve that could be measured. Blue stands here for **the image of deep water**, not for a means that would replenish an organ's energy through clothing or jewellery.

Why winter and rest?

In this tradition winter is the season of water and storing. In the garden you do not expect the same pace of growth in January as in May. Yet you sometimes expect the same performance from yourself every day, even after a demanding week. If you like dark blue, **keep** a blue blanket in the place where you rest and link it with the permission "I do not have to sort anything out now". If it feels cold to you, choose another.

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A personal talisman. A reminder that you do not have to give everything

A blue pebble, pendant or ribbon can connect to the theme of water and storing strength. Choose a single simple meaning: “I do not have to manage everything alone today.” There is no need to ascribe a hidden healing power to the object. Take it on a day when you tend to take on further duties and when you touch it, **allow yourself** to say “I will not take another task today.” If a piece of jewellery presses on you or a scarf irritates you, take it off. Bodily **comfort** is part of support.

Traditional Chinese medicine uses the elements as an image. It is not a diagnosis and does not replace a doctor.

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Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. In it a person is described by three types of "energy", the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are chosen to balance what there is too much of. Opposites are treated with opposites. Blue is cooling, calm and **soothing**.

How it relates to the colour blue. For Ayurveda blue is the colour of coolness and **calm**. That is why it is most often recommended where there is too much fire. Sources on colours in Ayurveda differ in detail, so take this as a general direction, not a rule.

Pitta

This is how a woman is described who is purposeful, quick and thorough, and flares up easily. Blue cools and **calms** her. The tradition advises cooling colours, such as blue, green or white.

- **Add blue**
  Light blue in a bedroom or study, a blue scarf, water on the table.
- **Add some cool**
  White and green, swimming, a walk by water.

Vata

This is how a woman is described who is imaginative and quick, but **restless**, who is often cold and sleeps worse. Cool colours may be too cool for vata, but other sources recommend soft light blue shades for **calming**. It is best to notice how you really feel in blue.

- **Warmer shades**
  A soft sky or dove blue. ***Calm*** *without coldness.*
- **Evening and sleep**
  Soft, muted shades and warm light.

Kapha

This is how a woman is described who is calm, steady and patient, but who easily becomes heavy. Some sources advise limiting cool colours for kapha, because she already has enough **calm** and coolness. Lively, warm colours suit her better.

- **Blue in moderation**
  A light, bright blue suits as an accent, not a dark and heavy one.
- **Add liveliness**
  Red, orange or yellow as a counterweight. A jumper, scarf, tablecloth.

A question for you

"Do you feel calm in blue, or chilled?"

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When you push everything forward. An image of cooling

Some contemporary Ayurvedic approaches recommend blue as a “cooling” colour for fiery pitta. They speak the language of qualities. Hot, sharp, quick against cool and calmer. Colour tables differ; blue is not a universal prescription according to a person's type.

What to imagine by it. You are in a hurry, you want to settle everything at once and by evening you have had enough of further stimuli. **You can** put aside a striking patterned throw and **try** a simple light blue fabric. If it feels more pleasant with it, it can belong to your evening wind-down. You are not treating body temperature this way; you are looking for an impression that does not nudge you to further performance.

When you already feel cold and withdrawn

You do not have to add a “cooling” colour just because a table says so. **Try** blue in a smaller area with a warm cream, a soft texture or natural wood. If you do not feel good in it, leave it for today. The choice can follow your experience, not an effort to meet a typology.

An online test will not reliably determine your dosha. If you are more interested, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. It is not treatment.

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A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have two layers. A personal one (what we have experienced with the colour) and one shared by all people (images that repeat across ages and cultures).

In his lectures at the ETH in Zurich he assigned blue to thinking: “Thinking is white or blue, cold as snow.” He was interested in how we think. **Distance**, clarity, a cool head. Elsewhere he wrote that blue means the mental process, reason (nous). Red for him belonged to feeling and green to sensation.

How it relates to the colour blue. Blue can remind you. Stop and look at it with **distance** and a cool head. What do I actually know and what do I only feel?

What you can take from it. When you are **overwhelmed** by feelings, blue in the form of **overview** helps. Write it on paper, say it aloud, look at the sky. When, on the contrary, you live only in your head and analyse everything, red (feeling) or green (body and senses) may do you good.

Try asking yourself

“What do I know today with my head and what do I only feel?”

Jung's ideas about colours are a symbolic framework, not verified science.

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Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging a space so that it is good to live in. In it blue, and especially dark blue, is the colour of water, the element of **calm**, **depth** and flow. Water belongs to winter and to the direction north. In the map of the house called the bagua, north is linked with career and life path. Blue is therefore usually the colour of **calm** and moving forward.

Blue is like water

> A little refreshes and calms, too much floods you.

In feng shui blue therefore often works best as an accent. A cushion, picture, ceramics or lamp gives a space **calm**. A blue wall, carpet and curtains all at once may feel more like a room where it is cold and company is missing.

Simple tips

- **Want more calm?**
  Add one blue piece in a place where you will see it every day.
- **Want more warmth?**
  Choose grey-blue or sky blue and complement them with wood, linen and warm light.
- **Is it already too much?**
  Add cream, orange, terracotta or more free space.
- **Do you want more voice?**
  Add a blue scarf or a pebble in your pocket and return to them every day.

And above all. Before you repaint a whole room, **try** a throw, a fabric or a larger colour sample. Your feeling is more important than the rules.

Water, or wood?

In some readings dark blue is assigned to water, in others an ordinary blue is linked with wood, that is with growth.

> So the same room can be both “watery” and “wooden”, depending on which school you read.

For your home **you can** take a simple question from this. Do I want to **calm** the space here, or set it flowing? One blue picture and four blue walls are two quite different experiences.

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What people say and what holds true

MYTH Water in a flat always brings money.

TRUTH The tradition speaks of balance, not a guaranteed result. Especially in a bedroom many schools warn against water features.

What blue works well with

- **Cream and linen**
  A softer whole in which blue does not chill.
- **Wood and clay**
  A more earthy, lived-in impression.
- **Orange and terracotta**
  A striking warm and cool contrast; try which will be the main one.
- **Green**
  A natural pair, recalls the sea and the forest. Watch the saturation of both colours.
- **Red**
  A strong contrast. In the language of the five elements water and fire are neighbours as adversaries, but in practice it is a matter of saturation and the size of areas.
- **Grey and white**
  A clean and calm whole. Make sure it is not too cold.

When you say the colours “fight energetically”, **you can** start concretely. Are both too saturated? Are there too many of them? Does their proportion not suit me? Change one thing and **try** spending some time in the room. Not just looking at it from the hall.

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Elements

In feng shui the elements are related to one another.

- **Water feeds wood**
  That is why green and plants suit blue.
- **Metal feeds water**
  White, grey and metal give blue freshness and restraint.
- **Earth holds water back**
  Brown, sand and terracotta ground and warm blue.
- **Water dampens fire**
  Symbolically the opposite of blue is red and orange.

Take it as a traditional picture of the relations between elements, not as a ban on combining two colours in one room. Feng shui has several schools and the recommendations differ.

MYTH Blue is always calm.

TRUTH A dark, cold blue throughout a flat can feel chilly and deadening. **Calm** comes rather from soft shades in balance with warmth.

MYTH The more blue, the more **calm**.

TRUTH When there is too much blue, warmth and closeness are missing. Blue with a companion is better than blue everywhere.

Clothing

Blue in clothing behaves similarly to blue in a flat. Best as a colour that **calms** you and gives you credibility. According to traditional advisers your personal element matters too. Water helps one person, blue is too cold for another. In practice. **Let** your body and the mirror advise you.

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Feng shui room by room

What works – what to watch for – a simple tip.

Living room

What works. Blue cushions, a picture with water or sky. They suit mainly the north part of a room. If your living room is grey and nobody much wants to sit in it, **try** a muted blue throw or two cushions next to a warm cream and wood.

What to watch for. If a dark sofa, a dark wall and blue curtains together feel oppressive, first swap the throw or draw back the curtains; **you do not have to** repaint at once.

A simple tip. Linen, wool and wood make blue softer and warmer. Glossy satin and glass make it cooler. From where does it feel good to look in the room and where does it feel good to sit?

Kitchen and dining room

What works. A blue bowl, mug or tile can be pleasant if you like **freshness**. Wood, linen and ceramics warm blue.

What to watch for. If a whole blue-grey kitchen with white light reminds you of a workplace and you miss **cosiness**, add wood, a warm white or a linen tablecloth. A glossy lacquer and stainless steel cool it.

A simple tip. **Try** an accessory first, you will see what changes before you start changing cabinets. Blue is not a ban for a kitchen or a guaranteed aid to weight loss. The evidence is weak and it depends on shade and light.

Bedroom

What works. Soft, muted shades (sky blue, grey-blue) help **calming**. Cotton and linen in blue-grey are pleasant to touch and when falling asleep.

What to watch for. A rich dark blue can be too cold; balance it with warm textiles. A large dark area behind the bed can feel like pressure. A stormy sea can be a beautiful picture, but if it arouses **tension** in you, put it elsewhere.

A simple tip. You need neither a fountain nor a blue night lamp. An object or picture that reminds you of **calm** is enough. What do you see just before you fall asleep and how does it feel to look at it?

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Children's room

What works. Lighter blue shades feel calm; a blue carpet, cushion or blanket is soft and movable.

What to watch for. Watch out for coldness. Add warm accessories and wood.

A simple tip. Let the child choose where their blue thing will stand. The child can feel it and decide for themselves.

Study

What works. Light blue helps concentration and **calm**, especially in combination with natural materials. A smaller blue area, the cover of a diary or a picture can belong to your focused time.

What to watch for. A rich electric blue on a large wall can disturb. **Try** a more muted shade or leave it only on an accessory. A glossy blue surface in the field of view can reflect into the eyes.

A simple tip. Blue helps here as a signal. When you finish in the evening, close the diary and put the work things away. It will not save a deadline, though. From where is it pleasant for you to see into the room?

Bathroom

What works. Water belongs here naturally. Turquoise and light blue feel fresh; blue towels or a small area of tiles carry an impression of cleanliness and water.

What to watch for. If you already have cold flooring, little daylight and glossy surfaces, another dark blue can strengthen the feeling of cold.

A simple tip. Balance it with a soft towel in a sandy tone, warmer light and fewer things on display. How does it feel to look at yourself in the mirror and what is reflected in it?

How to find your measure of blue

For a few days put a blue fabric or picture in the room. **Notice** in the morning and in the evening. Do I want to be here? Does the room feel cosy, open or cold to me? Then put the object aside for a while. **You do not have to** make a table or rate your feelings. In a shared flat leave room for the person who experiences the same colour differently.

Ask yourself

"Where in the flat does blue do me good and where does it chill me?"

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